

SUN SCREEN

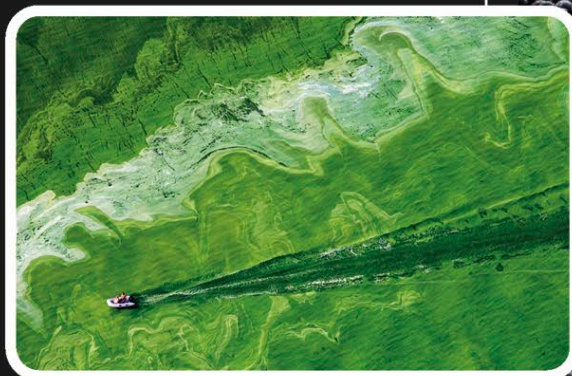
SHADE BALLS

In some dry, sunny regions, such as in California, black plastic spheres called shade balls are floated on water reservoirs to conserve water. They prevent water from evaporating, reduce the growth of algae, and also stop sunlight from reacting with chemicals in the water and making it unfit for drinking. It is estimated that this flexible, floating layer can help reduce evaporation by 85–90 percent and last for about 25 years. But some researchers worry that the prolonged use of plastic might cause toxic reactions in the water.

In 2019, more than **780 million** people worldwide struggled to get clean drinking water.

ALGAL BLOOMS

A boat cuts through the green surface of Lake Erie in Ohio, which has become choked with algae. Under certain conditions, these aquatic organisms multiply quickly, using up oxygen in the water and producing substances harmful to fish and other life.



PLASTICS

Plastics have many useful properties—they are lightweight and flexible, but also strong and water resistant. Plastics are made up of molecules called polymers, long strings of smaller molecules called monomers that usually contain hydrogen and carbon. Shade balls are made of the polymer polyethylene, which is made from ethylene molecules. It is also used to make bags, bottles, and many other things.

